the board of Tata Sons were at least on one of the boards of the thirteen large Tata companies. Together, they held twenty directorships.

In contrast, as on 31 March 2016, towards the end of Mistry's tenure, only two of the directors of Tata Sons were on the board of listed companies. Together, they held four directorships—Ishaat Hussain in Tata Steel, Voltas and TCS, and Amit Chandra in Tata Investment Corporation. Keeping the Tata veterans away from the board of Tata companies was wrong on Mistry's part, comments Hussain. But Mistry himself was director in six of the largest group companies—Tata Steel, Tata Motors, Tata Power, Tata Chemicals, TGBL and TCS—the combined revenues of which were nearly 80 per cent of that of the entire group and around 98 per cent of the total profit after tax of the listed companies in 2012.

'We had gained strength by being one group rather than an amalgamation of companies', created a 'common logo … we did all of that', says Ratan. But Mistry, on the contrary, sent a message that 'each company should do its own thing'.

Ratan was consternated that the 'existing structure of the group' forged by the 'visionary founders and generations of Tatas' was being 'consciously dismantled' by Mistry. Mistry had changed the system in many ways and was engineering the drifting of companies away from Tata Sons 'where the Chairman [Mistry] alone is the only common Director across several companies and this situation could not be allowed to go on', said a statement issued by Tata Sons.

When asked if the conduct of Mistry gave any room for suspicion that he may have planned for the ultimate dismantlement of Tata Sons, Ratan declines to respond.

Soonawala opines that the motives of Mistry were suspect. But he seems to imply that it was long in coming. 'It became very obvious two years too late,' he comments. Now, 'you can draw your conclusions,' he says. But he also added, 'It never came to the test.'

Chandrasekaran says that it is 'very difficult to comment' on this issue but adds that 'there is a commentary like that'. He also confides that he had seen the note that Mistry shared with the selection committee on what a chairman of Tata Sons should do. He says with a sense of astonishment: 'But he [Mistry] just simply did not, simply did not, implement anything to do with that including the appointment of a vice-chairman and also the appointment of group people on the board of Tata Sons who [would] be put